



VENEZUELA

Capital city: Caracas
Area: 352,143 sq miles (912,050 sq km)
Population: 25,700,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 99%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Bolivar
Adult literacy rate: 93%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 417
Televisions: 185 per 1,000 people

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WHEN THE ITALIAN EXPLORER Amerigo Vespucci first visited the southern shores of the Caribbean Sea in 1499, he named the land Venezuela, or "Little Venice." The lake dwellings of the native Indians reminded him of the houses and canals of the Italian city of Venice. Part of the Spanish Empire for three centuries, Venezuela became independent in 1811.

Today it is a country of huge contrasts: the oil industry produces immense wealth, yet many people live in shantytowns. Most people live in cities, yet the tribes of the interior are barely touched by modern life.



SLASH AND BURN AGRICULTURE

In parts of the Amazon rain forest in Venezuela farmers practice a type of agriculture called slash and burn. This is where virgin rain forest is cut down and burned in order to provide farm land.

The land cannot sustain being cultivated for long, so after a few years more forest must be destroyed for farmers to continue growing crops.

RAIN FOREST TRIBES

The few native peoples who still survive in Venezuela live in the remote interior of the country near the border with Brazil. The main group is the Yanomami and numbers about 10,000 people. The Yanomami are hunters and gatherers who live in enormous thatched huts called *yanos*, built in clearings in the forest. Their way of life is threatened both by logging companies and mineral prospectors anxious to exploit the wealth of the region, and by measles and other diseases against which they have no defense.

Circular yanos contain between 10 and 20 families, each living in its own section.



Yanos are made from wooden beams covered with palm branches and supported by tall poles; the central part is often open to the sky.



Yanomami men hunt wild animals for food. Boys are trained to hunt from an early age.

YOUNG VENEZUELA

Out of a total population in Venezuela of 25 million, more than 7 million people are under the age of 15. The majority of them live in the cities of the north. Many enjoy US activities such as playing baseball (introduced by workers in the oil industry) and listening to rock music.



HIGH-RISE CARACAS

For most of its 400-year history, Caracas was a sleepy town 2,950 ft (900 m) up in the hills near the Caribbean coastline. With the discovery of oil, the population rapidly rose from a few thousand to more than 4 million. Today, Caracas is a modern city, with steel and glass architecture, an extensive highway, and a subway system.

Where people live



87% live in cities

13% live in the country



OIL WEALTH

The discovery of oil in Lake Maracaibo, in 1917, transformed Venezuela from one of the poorest countries in South America to one of the richest. The reserves underneath Lake Maracaibo are the biggest outside of the Middle East; oil-bearing beds of tar by the Orinoco River add to the country's wealth. Despite these reserves, many people remain poor. Public services and agriculture have been neglected, and the rise and fall of oil prices has affected the economy.

CABLE CAR

Far above the city of Mérida is the world's highest cable car system. It carries passengers from the city up to 15,600 ft (4,765 m) above sea level. The journey is in four stages and takes more than an hour.

Find out more

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